

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Warehouse and Distribution English



Vocabulary & phrasebook

Keep precise meanings and useful expressions close. Retrieve the words, then use them in a complete message.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For Warehouse associates, receivers, pickers, packers, returns staff, and inventory clerks.

All cases, quantities, codes, people, and arrangements are fictional English practice, not warehouse, equipment, lifting, hazardous-material, or safety training. Local stock controls and duties vary. Use employer training for physical tasks; refer equipment operation, hazardous conditions, inventory adjustments, and release decisions to the responsible qualified staff. Scripts teach communication, not handling methods.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Make vocabulary usable

Knowing a definition is a start. To use a term well, explain it in plain English, connect it to a case, and choose a natural sentence around it.

- Read five terms, cover their definitions, and recall the meanings.
- Sort a pair you might confuse and explain the difference.
- Use one term in a sentence about a fictional case.
- Ask a partner to explain the sentence without repeating the specialist word.
- Return to the same terms on another day and test recall again.

Abbreviations need context

Expand an abbreviation on first use when the listener needs it. Some abbreviations have different meanings across professions: API can refer to an application programming interface or an active pharmaceutical ingredient. The course context determines the meaning.

Definitions have limits

These are concise language-learning explanations, not complete legal, clinical, or technical specifications. Use the applicable authoritative definition for regulated or operational decisions.

Field vocabulary A-Z

advance shipping notice

A supplier's message describing goods expected to arrive, often shortened to ASN.

allocation

Stock assigned or reserved for a particular order or purpose.

bin location

The coded storage position assigned to stock within a warehouse.

carrier cutoff

The latest agreed time for goods or bookings to meet a specified carrier departure.

carton identifier

A unique reference used to distinguish a particular shipping carton.

case pack

The number of individual units supplied in a standard case.

cycle count

A scheduled count of selected stock rather than a full warehouse inventory.

dispatch confirmation

A record confirming that goods have actually been dispatched, not merely prepared.

disposition

The approved decision about what happens next to goods, such as restocking or supplier return.

each

One individual sale or stock unit, rather than a group of units.

inspection hold

A status preventing ordinary release while goods await a required condition check.

inventory variance

A difference between the physical stock count and the recorded quantity.

load manifest

The list identifying shipments or handling units assigned to a particular load.

lot number

An identifier linking units produced or supplied as one particular batch.

overage

A quantity received above the quantity expected for that shipment.

packing station

The work area where picked goods are checked and prepared for dispatch.

pick ticket

The instruction identifying items, quantities, and locations for an order pick.

purchase order

A buyer's order identifying requested goods and quantities, often shortened to PO.

putaway

The placement and recording of received goods in their assigned storage locations.

receiving discrepancy

A difference between an arriving shipment and its expected quantity, identity, or condition.

replenishment

The movement of stock into a picking location from another storage area.

reserve stock

Stock held outside the main picking location for later use.

restock

To return eligible goods to available inventory after required checks and approval.

returns intake

The receipt and identification of goods coming back into the warehouse.

scan confirmation

A system acknowledgment that a particular barcode or item scan was registered.

shift handoff

The transfer of work status and outstanding issues to the next shift.

shipping label

The label carrying delivery and carrier information for a shipment.

short pick

A pick that cannot supply the full requested quantity from the identified available stock.

staging lane

A designated area where outbound goods wait for their next transport movement.

stock keeping unit

An identifier for a distinct stocked product or variant, commonly shortened to SKU.

transaction history

The record of stock movements and adjustments affecting an item.

unit of measure

The counting basis used for an item, such as each, case, or pallet.

Expressions for this course

Complete the frames with the facts of your case. A frame helps organize meaning; it should not replace an actual explanation.

Report the extra quantity precisely

We expected ____; we counted ____.

The labels match, but ____ remains unclear.

Please refer the quantity difference to ____.

A matching label does not by itself approve an order increase.

Word combinations in this lesson

compare the expected quantity: check arrival against the notice

report an overage: identify extra units with their reference

match the purchase order: link goods to the buyer's order

keep the discrepancy open: avoid calling an unresolved difference settled

Read beyond a shared code prefix

The task specifies ____; the carton shows ____.

Is ____ the location code or the item code?

Please check the record for ____.

Product, variant, lot, and location identify different things. Repeat the full code.

Word combinations in this lesson

read the full item code: include the variant suffix

verify the bin location: confirm the assigned storage position

check the lot number: distinguish batches of the same product

query the putaway record: ask where receipt was recorded as stored

Make the counting unit audible

The ticket says ___ each, not ___ cases.

For this item, one case contains ___.

Please repeat the quantity with ___.

Say the amount and unit together. A case pack varies by item.

Word combinations in this lesson

confirm the unit of measure: establish what the quantity counts

pick by each: count individual units for the order

check the case pack: verify units per case

read back the pick quantity: repeat amount and counting unit together

Ask for the missing stock information

The short pick is ___ units for order ___.

Reserve shows ___, but ___ needs checking.

Can you confirm ___ before ___?

Reserve quantity, order allocation, and completed replenishment are different statuses.

Word combinations in this lesson

report the short pick: state requested and available quantities

request replenishment: ask for stock at the pick location

check reserve availability: distinguish stored quantity from usable quantity

confirm the allocation: verify which order the stock belongs to

Interrupt a mismatched label politely

Please pause ___; these references differ.

The screen says ___, whereas the label says ___.

Let's compare ___ before ___.

Physical proximity does not prove that a loose label belongs to a carton.

Word combinations in this lesson

match the carton identifier: link the physical carton and record

query a label mismatch: flag conflicting shipping information

confirm the scan result: check which reference was registered

separate adjacent orders: keep goods and labels linked to the right customer

Name the stage accurately

___ cartons are staged in ___.

The manifest includes ___, leaving ___ unresolved.

Departure is ___, not ___.

A staging location, manifest entry, and departure confirmation provide different evidence.

Word combinations in this lesson

check the staging lane: verify the assigned outbound location

compare against the manifest: match staged goods to the load list

flag the carrier cutoff: state the departure-related deadline

distinguish staged from dispatched: name the actual transport stage

Separate received from released

The reference matches; condition is ___.

The item is received but not ___.

___ owns the disposition review.

A return can be identified and received while its condition remains unverified.

Word combinations in this lesson

match the return authorization: identify the approved return

place on inspection hold: record that release awaits review

request a disposition decision: ask the responsible team for the next status

confirm eligibility to restock: verify release criteria have been met

Transfer the discrepancy, not a guessed cause

Both counts show ___; the system shows ___.

The variance is confirmed, but the cause is ___.

Please take ___ and acknowledge ___.

A reliable recount can establish a difference without explaining it.

Word combinations in this lesson

report a count variance: give physical and recorded quantities

check transaction history: look for relevant recorded movements

name the unresolved item: specify the count or order needing follow-up

acknowledge the handoff: confirm receipt and ownership of the next task

Model responses in context

Read the situation first. Cover the model, say your own response, and compare the two for meaning and tone.

01 | Receiving against the expected shipment

Purchase order 740 expects twenty cartons. Receiving counts twenty-two with matching item labels. The supplier has not explained the additional two; the clerk can flag an overage but cannot approve an order change.

Purchase order 740 expects twenty cartons, and our receiving count is twenty-two. The item labels match, but we haven't confirmed why there are two extra cartons. I'll report an overage against this receipt. Please keep the expected quantity unchanged until the purchasing contact clarifies whether the additional goods belong to this order.

Try it again: A colleague suggests replacing the expected quantity with the count. Explain why both figures matter.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

02 | Locating and identifying stock

A picker needs item BK-14-B, blue folders. Bin A12 contains BK-14-G, green folders. The bin sign says BK-14-B. Inventory clerk can check the putaway record; no move or substitution has been approved.

The task calls for BK-14-B, blue folders, but the cartons in A12 are labeled BK-14-G, green folders. The bin sign agrees with the task, not the carton labels. Could you check the putaway record for these two variants? I haven't treated the shared BK-14 prefix as proof that they are interchangeable.

Try it again: A matching photograph is offered as proof. Ask for the full item identifier instead.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

03 | Picking the right unit and quantity

Pick ticket S18 asks for six each of a storage tray. A standard case holds six trays. A coworker reads it as six cases. Confirm one case contains the six requested units, without assuming other products share that pack size.

S18 calls for six each, meaning six individual trays. The listed case pack for this item is six, so that quantity corresponds to one complete case, not six cases. Could you read back the order quantity with its unit? We should keep this item's pack size separate from any other tray variant.

Try it again: Another tray has a case pack of eight. Explain why the S18 calculation does not transfer to it.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

04 | Reporting a short pick and replenishment need

Order D55 needs ten baskets; pick face B04 has four. System lists twelve in reserve, but allocation and availability have not been checked. Replenishment desk can review; cutoff is 15:00.

Order D55 needs ten baskets, and B04 currently has four, leaving a six-unit short pick. The system lists twelve in reserve, but I haven't confirmed whether they are available to this order. Could you check allocation and replenishment status before the three o'clock cutoff and tell me whether the remaining six can be supplied?

Try it again: The replenishment request is accepted. Explain why accepted does not yet mean the pick face has been refilled.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

05 | Packing and label discrepancies

Packing station 3 has cartons C70 and C71. C70's screen names Harbor Shop, but the loose label beside it names Hillside School for C71. No label has been applied. Ask the packer to pause the label match while both references are checked.

Please pause the label match at station three. The screen for carton C70 names Harbor Shop, while this loose label names Hillside School and C71. Nothing has been applied yet. Could we compare both carton identifiers and their records before continuing? The labels' position on the bench doesn't establish which order they belong to.

Try it again: A successful scan is offered as proof of correct packing. Ask which identifier was scanned and what that scan confirms.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

06 | Staging and dispatch status

Three cartons for order L66 are staged in lane 2. Manifest lists only two. Carrier cutoff is 16:00; goods have not departed. Dispatch clerk can investigate the missing carton entry.

L66 has three cartons staged in lane two, but the load manifest lists only two. Nothing has departed yet, so the order is staged, not dispatched. Could dispatch check the missing carton entry before the four o'clock carrier cutoff? I can confirm the physical count without claiming that the load list is complete.

Try it again: Carrier collection is delayed. Give the current staged status without inventing a new departure time.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

07 | Returns and stock status

Returned kettle K25 matches its return reference. Packaging appears unopened, but condition review is pending. Intake worker cannot mark it ready for sale; returns checker Mira owns the review.

K25 matches the return reference, and its packaging appears unopened. That appearance does not confirm its condition or eligibility for restocking. The return is received and awaiting Mira's inspection decision. Please keep the inspection hold distinct from available stock until the returns team confirms the disposition for this item.

Try it again: A colleague calls the item defective. Correct the label: uninspected does not establish a defect.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

08 | Inventory and shift handoffs

Cycle count for item T9 in B11 found eighteen; the system shows twenty. No cause is confirmed. Evening clerk Sam can review transaction history. Recount is complete and agrees at eighteen; no stock adjustment is approved.

T9 in B11 counted eighteen on both counts; the system shows twenty. The two-unit variance is confirmed, but its cause isn't. No adjustment has been approved. Sam, please review the transaction history and take this discrepancy into the evening handoff. Can you confirm that you'll investigate the difference without treating a proposed explanation as established?

Try it again: A transfer appears in history but its timing is unclear. Explain why a possible explanation still needs checking.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

Use the language responsibly

All cases, quantities, codes, people, and arrangements are fictional English practice, not warehouse, equipment, lifting, hazardous-material, or safety training. Local stock controls and duties vary. Use employer training for physical tasks; refer equipment operation, hazardous conditions, inventory adjustments, and release decisions to the responsible qualified staff. Scripts teach communication, not handling methods.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

BLS Occupational Outlook Handbook: Hand Laborers and Material Movers

<https://www.bls.gov/ooh/transportation-and-material-moving/hand-laborers-and-material-movers.htm>

OSHA: Warehousing Overview

<https://www.osha.gov/warehousing>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the following prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Vocabulary and grammar prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has four practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

Each starter prompt uses B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-30. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Build vocabulary and collocations

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT | ONLINE VERSION

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Warehouse and Distribution English

Professional audience: Warehouse associates, receivers, pickers, packers, returns staff, and inventory clerks

Scope: All cases, quantities, codes, people, and arrangements are fictional English practice, not warehouse, equipment, lifting, hazardous-material, or safety training. Local stock controls and duties vary. Use employer training for physical tasks; refer equipment operation, hazardous conditions, inventory adjustments, and release decisions to the responsible qualified staff. Scripts teach communication, not handling methods.

Lesson 01: Receiving against the expected shipment

Original fictional case: Purchase order 740 expects twenty cartons. Receiving counts twenty-two with matching item labels. The supplier has not explained the additional two; the clerk can flag an overage but cannot approve an order change.

Language workshop: Report the extra quantity precisely

Communication goal: Separate receipt facts from a purchasing decision.

Language guidance: A matching label does not by itself approve an order increase.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): We expected ____; we counted _____. / The labels match, but ____ remains unclear. / Please refer the quantity difference to ____.

Vocabulary: advance shipping notice: A supplier's message describing goods expected to arrive, often shortened to ASN. / receiving discrepancy: A difference between an arriving shipment and its expected quantity, identity, or condition. / purchase order: A buyer's order identifying requested goods and quantities, often shortened to PO. / overage: A quantity received above the quantity expected for that shipment.

Speaking task: Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: Buyer: only twenty were ordered; you must ask the supplier about the additional two.

Guided response task: Complete a workplace dialogue by selecting one of four supplied options. Compare the feedback and say the completed exchange aloud. Do not write an open-ended message.

Optional second-round challenge: A colleague suggests replacing the expected quantity with the count. Explain why both figures matter.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: Purchase order 740 expects twenty cartons, and our receiving count is twenty-two. The item labels match, but we haven't confirmed why there are two extra cartons. I'll report an overage against this receipt. Please keep the expected quantity unchanged until the purchasing contact clarifies whether the additional goods belong to this order.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Retrieve occupational vocabulary

1. Select four terms from the reference. Explain each in plain English, give two natural collocations and quote or create a short workplace example. Label invented examples. Contrast each term with a plausible confusable term; acknowledge regional variation.
2. Present one role-labelled exchange with one missing word or phrase and four choices A-D. Exactly one choice must fit the stated facts and grammar. Stop and wait for my answer before revealing it.
3. Explain all four options, then invite me to read the completed exchange aloud. Offer a sentence frame for optional spoken practice, never an open-ended writing assignment.
4. Repeat for the other three terms, one question at a time. Vary the correct letter and the situation; preserve the reference facts. If a choice is ambiguous, replace the item.
5. Finish with two new four-choice collocation questions for later review, with a clearly separate answer key. Do not claim to schedule a reminder.

END PROMPT